into India’s defence inventory. Security cooperation is another important element of this strategy, specifically bilateral (and multilateral) military exercises, security dialogues, and military-to-military exchanges, which have taken place with steadfast regularity since 2000. Security cooperation creates a common institutional and policy framework within which India and Japan can develop their military capabilities. It ensures to some degree that India will develop its arsenal and military doctrine in a manner that in a time of future crisis might permit coordinated activities with Japan (and the United States) ranging from simple tasks such as the geostrategic division of labour to far more complex tasks such as joint operations.

Investing in policy coordination

Coordination is important not just at the operational level but also in terms of strategy. A shared strategy or vision for the Indo-Pacific region – a term championed by Abe since before his first tenure as Prime Minister in the mid-2000s – is the cornerstone of the India–Japan relationship. The Japan–India Joint Statement issued during Abe’s visit to India in September 2017 highlighted the commitment of both countries to their

> values-based partnership in achieving a free, open and prosperous Indo-Pacific region where sovereignty and international law are respected, and differences are resolved through dialogue, and where all countries, large or small, enjoy freedom of navigation and overflight, sustainable development, and a free, fair, and open trade and investment system.[27]